

Washington Monument

An obelisk evoking the power of an ancient civilization, built to honor a new nation's founding father

Given its importance as a national landmark, the Washington Monument in the US capital had a perilous gestation. Built to honor George Washington (1732–1799), the first president of the US, the monument was started in 1848, but construction work was halted from 1854 to 1876 due to lack of funds and the intervention of the Civil War. It was eventually completed in 1884.

The original design for the monument by Robert Mills imagined a 600-ft- (183-m-) high obelisk surrounded by 30 pillars that were 100 ft (30 m) high, but the plans were scaled down when building resumed in 1876. The monument is a hollow obelisk made of marble, granite, and bluestone gneiss that stands 555 ft (169 m) high, capped by a 55-ft- (16.8-m-) high pyramidion.



△ VIEW FROM THE TOP

The obelisk is capped by a hollow marble pyramidion (a small pyramid), at the apex of which is a smaller aluminum pyramid, part of the monument's lightning conductor.



Flatiron Building

A wedge-shaped skyscraper that came to symbolize New York's confidence and ambition

This dramatic Manhattan skyscraper owes its aggressive wedge-shape to a desire to make best use of expensive New York real estate. The site itself was known in the 1850s as Eno's flatiron, after the owner Amos Eno and its clothes-iron-like shape. The land was sold in 1901 to an investment partnership created by Harry S. Black of the George A. Fuller Company. Their new building was to be named the Fuller Building, but locals persisted in calling it the Flatiron.

Construction started in June 1901 and proceeded at a fast pace, as the steel used for the building's skeleton was precut, enabling the skyscraper to rise by a story a week. The 22-story building was finished in June 1902. The design by Daniel Burnham takes the form of a vertical Renaissance palazzo with Beaux Arts styling. The overall form of the Flatiron is based on a Classical Greek column, with a limestone base and a glazed terracotta shaft and capitol on top.

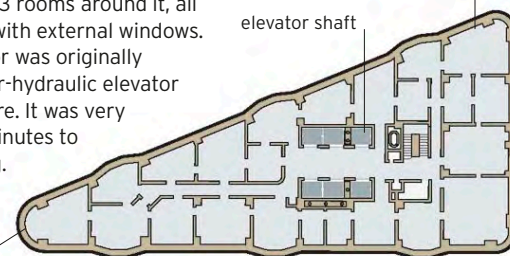
THE RIGHT TRIANGLE

The building is in the shape of a right-angled triangle. Each floor consists of a central lobby and corridor with 23 rooms around it, all but three of them with external windows. Access to each floor was originally provided by a water-hydraulic elevator powered by pressure. It was very slow and took 10 minutes to ascend the building.

northern end has an acute angle of 25 degrees

Broadway front is 190 ft (57.9 m) wide

elevator shaft



◁ STEEL SKELETON

In 1892 New York City removed its requirement that masonry had to be used for fireproofing a building, allowing new buildings, such as the Flatiron, to be constructed using a steel skeleton.

▷ BEAUX ARTS STYLE

The glazed terracotta tiles that cover the Flatiron Building are purely decorative; they have no structural role but merely cover up the steel skeleton that holds and supports the building.